EXHIBITION

PICTURE PERFECT

'Becoming' celebrates 130 years of art, illustrations in Indian children's books

Abanindranath Tagore's *Khirer Putul* in Bangla, published in 1896, is one of the first printed children's books in India for leisure reading. Tagore, his protégé Nandalal Bose, Upendrakishore Ray Chowdhury (who founded the Bangla children's magazine *Sandesh*), his son Sukumar Ray and grandson Satyajit Ray were the pioneers of children's book illustrations in India.

A new exhibition in the capital celebrates 130 years of illustrations in children's books in India. Curated by award-winning children's author and Pickle Yolk Books publisher Richa Jha, *Becoming* includes more than 100 illustrations from books published by 24 publishers. It features artworks by 75 of some of the most loved and acclaimed artists and illustrators, contemporary and past, whose illustrations in books for children have fed and delighted generations of young minds in the country.

"The curation is arranged to reflect the many 'becomings' of the spaces in our lives, and of the self, and those of their nebulous intersections with time, to look at the many aspects of becoming," explains Jha. Though not a chronological and historical exposition, it is an apt lens from which to soak in the changing contours of children's book art through the decades in terms of the illustrations' evolving sensibilities, styles and scope. "So, while we have illustrations by late veterans like Mickey Patel, Jagdish Joshi and Pulak Biswas, we also have those by some brilliant contemporary artists, all sitting equally tall and happy next to one another," adds Jha.

BECOMING is on from April 23-May 6 at the Art Gallery, Kamaladevi Complex, India International Centre, Delhi

Several events have been planned as part of the exhibition, including curatorial tours, panel discussions, book reading sessions and a reading zone. There will also be two workshops for art students on picture book making and illustrations for children's magazines, facilitated by award-winning artists Ruchi Shah and Taposhi Ghoshal, respectively; an art workshop for senior school students facilitated by acclaimed illustrators Suvidha Mistry and Mistunee Chowdhury; as well as a workshop on the many journeys of an artist's sketchbook facilitated by Habib Ali and Shubham Lakhera.

Apart from this, there will be a few interesting installations to engage visitors with the exhibited illustrations. There will also be a small wall dedicated to the Bengali pioneers who first introduced the idea of illustrations in children's literature. "The exhibition is meant as a huge celebratory shoutout to our bustling community of illustrators, designers, art directors, editors, authors, translators and publishers who are pouring their love and passion into creating fabulous illustrated books for children," concludes Jha, who plans to make *Becoming* a travelling exhibition in the future. ■

–Neha Kirpal







FINE LINES (Clockwise from above) Sukumar Ray's illustration in *Abol Tabol*, Anitha Balachandran for *Mister Jeejeebhoy and the Birds*, Upendrakishore Roychowdhury in *Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne*